

this magazine because of what was on the cover, flipped past the initial pages, and came directly to this story. Whether you'd like to admit it or not, sex really *does* sell; it rouses our curiosity and plays to the voyeur in us all. It's like reading the sex advice columns in tabloids—you may not have any of those problems, but the curiosity that killed the proverbial cat gets the better of you.

Take a look at the content on most TV channels today, from the ads to the soaps—everything is laced with sex and double-meanings. We're not here to debate whether that's bad or good, and we'll leave it to the public, the moral police and campaigning politicians to sort it all out amongst themselves, but what we see on TV is quite sanitary compared to what's online.

With Internet penetration increasing by the day, and people moving from dial-up to "broadband" across the country, the demographics of the Indian Internet populace is changing by the minute. Kids and grandparents alike now get online, and almost every urban Indian has access to the big bad Net from either home or office, or both.

Back to the point: Sex sells! Sexy ads all try to appeal to our sexual personas. Being sexy is a requirement today, and ads make you "want to be" even more. At least there's a governing body for television, and this prevents the content from getting too wild. The Internet, however, is another story altogether, and it's not so much about sex here as it is about pornography. Because of the freedom the Net affords, there's no need to be subtle: content there ranges from the mildly titillating to the horrendously explicit.

Who Am I?

On the Internet, no one except *you* knows that for sure—and sometimes even you will not. Anonymity is the ultimate aphrodisiac, the

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battering ram for our moral barriers, and the stripper of our inhibitions. Perhaps that's why there is so much of a market for pornography—child pornography included. It's because most of the people who buy or trade illegal pictures and videos do so knowing that it will be hard, if not impossible, to track them down.

It's not just to pornography that anonymity lends a helping hand, but also to hacking, warez trading and more. Most of us have done something illegal online—but what's more important is that none of us care, or need to worry about getting caught.

The Truth About Your Kids

We're raising a generation of tech-savvy kids who know how easy it is to get absolutely any type of content online. Kids today don't need to hide dirty *magazines* under their beds like earlier generations did. I remember a friend in school who had a lingerie catalogue smuggled in from the US—that's what we considered pornography in the late '80s. Today, almost every teenager who goes online has a folder on his hard drive that's full of *hardcore* (very explicit) pornographic images and videos. Depending on his parents' knowledge of computers, this folder might be in plain sight, hidden, or even encrypted.

Most porn is targeted at men—or boys! If you have a son who goes online, he has in all probability been exposed to pornography. If not through e-mail, then through friends, chat buddies, while surfing, and from Web searches. Look at the bright side though: you don't have to have that talk with him about the birds and the bees—the Internet gave him a full audio-visual presentation!

The Talk

Most surveys show that parents are too uncomfortable to talk to their kids about sex. Schools and colleges have started sex education (or whatever is the politically correct name for it), but those classes are more like biology lessons than anything else. Kids don't need biology lessons! Do they really need to see poor cross-sections of the human anatomy? Especially when you consider that they can get more practical, close-up pictures of said anatomy being *used* in 15 seconds flat if you give them a computer and an Internet connection—which you already have, incidentally!

"Women = Meat." That's what many experts say is the popular perception boys and men have, thanks to pornography. Interestingly, this is *less* true in sexually liberated cultures, like in Western countries. In India, where saying the word "sex" is likely to get you slapped, most men have nothing but pornography to help form their opinions and aid in the sexual growth from teenager to man. This is where your "talk" comes in. You don't need to explain sex to your teenager—they already know *that!* What experts are pleading for is that parents teach their kids the value of love and the methods to prevent against diseases like AIDS. With India having recently overtaken South Africa to become the country with the most HIV+ people, you'd better start talking soon!

The Pornographers

Pornographic sites are dominating the Net, but they're being a little more careful about how they distribute their content. The credit card age verification process that a lot of them have adopted is proof of that. Though this tactic is being used by a few to charge your cards surreptitiously, a lot of them actually use this method to verify age. Some sites also put up large warnings that say "You must be 18 or older to enter." All of them proclaim that all their "models" are 18 or older, and direct you away from their sites if you say you're not 18.

However, like everything else, this is a business, and ethics are a pipe dream. You will still get spam in your e-mail from such sites, and often, opening one of them pops up more and more of their sister sites.

There was this whole ado about .xxx domains: pornographers didn't want to be limited to one domain suffix, even though that would make them easier to address their target audience. It would reduce their business, because content would be so easy to control—all you would have to do is block .xxx sites and you could be sure that your children are safe. For the pornographer, this would mean that most search engines would just block .xxx sites from being displayed in results, unless the searcher specifically asked for them. This would cut back on the amount of people who stumble across sites while surfing—a fairly large number.

A site is global, and access to it has absolutely nothing to do with where in the world it's hosted—while laws have *everything* to do with where it's being hosted—that's the ambiguity of Internet law! Since the Internet belongs to no country, there are no laws that can govern it. Even when countries do make laws, the people who want to do so find loopholes or just move shop to a more sympathetic country.